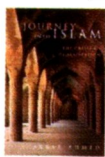


AMONG THE BELIEVERS

An expatriate Pakistani intellectual's flawed search for the post-September 11 Islamic soul



JOURNEY INTO ISLAM: THE CRISIS OF GLOBALIZATION
by AKBAR S. AHMED
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■ By Saeed Naqvi

Folks from the subcontinent, who take up residence in the United States and within a few years begin to refer to themselves in their public pronouncements as "we Americans", never fail to amaze me. Akbar Ahmed, author of *Journey Into Islam: The Crisis of Globalization*, is a Pakistani who has yielded to this temptation. Ahmed has been Pakistan's High Commissioner in London for a few months, prior to which he was dabbling in a fawning documentary on Jinnah.

In indicating a preference for London, Ahmed follows a long tradition of Pakistani politicians, intellectuals and poets. *Journey Into Islam* came to fruition after Ahmed made Washington DC his home. It was while he taught there that 9/11 happened. He had the brilliant idea of picking up two of his students, of Jewish and Christian extraction, to travel with him to Muslim countries of the Middle East, South-East Asia and South Asia. Some trusts coughed up the money and off the trio went, incorporating other young scholars along the way.

Ahmed begins the narrative from the famous Islamic seminary, Deoband, in Uttar Pradesh. Take this description of his journey: "I began my journey on this isolated, narrow road, several hours from Delhi. If we were taken hostage or chopped up into little bits, I whispered to my young American team, no one will know about it for at least two weeks." What a horrible cliché of a joke. On the drive

to Deoband, seated in front, is one of the institute's important functionaries, Aijaz Qasmi. Haily Woldt, one of Ahmed's companions (the other is Frankie Martin) scribbles a note to Ahmed in indignation: "He won't look at me." This gives Ahmed the opportunity to explain. "As a Muslim I understood that for him this was orthodox."

There are some fixations Ahmed cannot avoid: one is himself. Across the pages we are reminded on countless occasions what various interlocutors thought of him. His second fixation is Jinnah. He cannot resist the temptation of asking all and sundry if Jinnah fits the bill as a modern Muslim leader. Maulana Azad does not figure in his

When Mustafa Kamal Pasha Atatürk adopted Swiss Law as the Personal Law for Turks, he meant exactly this: the Prophet would have recommended the most enlightened law available. By the Ajmeri School he means Sufism. The reference is to Moinuddin Chishti, the great Sufi saint, whose shrine is in Ajmer. Sufism, which spread in India alongside Bhakti from the 12th century, became the earliest powerful Islamic influence on the subcontinent.

Ahmed lumps Maulana Maududi, founder of Jamaat-e-Islami, with Deoband, which is a mistake. He is shy of elaborating on Wahabism; he does not even name Saudi Arabia as the country of origin of the 9/11 hijackers.

Nor does he enlighten us about Iran, currently in the eye of a storm. In his concluding chapters he establishes how Muslims in various Islamic countries are out of sync with their rulers.

What is the solution? Well, more such travels by Ahmed. The remarkable conversion of Qasmi of Deoband is a result of Ahmed's exertion. When Qasmi first guided the trio to Deoband, he thought the killing of American and Israeli women and children was part of Jihad. But during the

following week he heard the voice of sanity, i.e., Ahmed addressing various Muslim gatherings in India. Just when the author was about to depart, a transformed Qasmi offered to translate into Urdu Ahmed's earlier book, *Islam Under Siege*.

The book is a fund of useful conversations with various leaders and Muslim clerics. But the ultimate cure for our troubled times is for Ahmed to hit the road with his students, throughout the Muslim world, and one by one transform many more Qasmis into interfaith specialists. He does not say so, but he means it.



calculus even as an intellectual.

Ahmed has very neatly (in some ways inaccurately) drawn up three Muslim models: Deoband, Aligarh and Ajmeri. Even for uninitiated Americans, the classification is inadequate. By Deoband he means Wahabis, the source of all our Jihadi troubles—Osama bin Laden et al. But he does not say it in so many words. By the Aligarh model, he means Sir Sayyad's pursuit of western education as salvation for the community. The Quran, Sir Sayyad implied, is God's word for all ages and can therefore be reinterpreted in the light of contemporary circumstances.